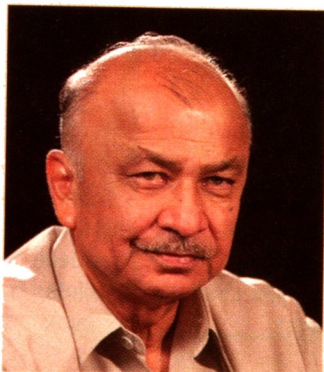


UMILIATED



P. MUKHERJEE

The Left lobbied hard for the fellow Bengali but Sonia wasn't impressed. The ostensible reason was that Pranab was "indispensable", but he lacked the loyalty quotient. If he wasn't to be trusted in a job where he could be moved, could they trust him where he wouldn't be touched?



S.K. SHINDE

When nobody was willing to take on Shekhawat in 2002, Shinde stepped in to lose a lost battle. But it didn't help. K.R. Narayanan had already been the first Dalit President. Thanks to the Mayawati factor, the party wanted to tilt its bias towards an upper caste Hindu for President.



MOHSINA KIDWAI

She is the mascot who heralded the return of Indira Gandhi after the Emergency. She was named, shortlisted and briefly discussed. She made it on the woman quota but sadly lost out because she was a Muslim. The party didn't want another Muslim President quite so soon.



N. DESHPANDE

The ultimate Gandhian, Nirmala would also have been the marathi *manoos* who could have been the first woman President. Ostensibly, it was her health but truth be told she was seen only as a Gandhian and lacked the double-barrelled Nehru-Gandhi credentials.

not in her name, but the fact of default by a cooperative where she was the chairperson cannot be denied. Pawar, who sprang to her defence, said 74 sugar mills had been issued notices. True, but promoters of the other 73 are not contesting for the post of the supreme custodian of the Constitution.

Take the issue of the murder of Professor Vishram Patil, who was the district president of the Jalgaon Congress Committee. After defeating Pratibha's brother G.N. Patil for the post, he discovered a misuse of funds collected for tsunami relief in 2005. "The funds were not collected by Pratibha. I understand they have been deposited with the collector with a valid receipt," defends I&B Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi. Vishram wrote letters to MPCC chief Prabha Rau (on April 21), AICC General Secretary Margaret Alva (on August 3) and Maharashtra Governor S.M. Krishna (on August 25), alleging misappropriation of nearly Rs 2 lakh. On September 21, 2005, he was murdered. In Jalgaon, Congressmen whisper how "Tai" never even went to offer condolences. The "culprits" were arrested, but they alleged that they were forced to confess the crime. One of the accused, Raju Mali, who alleged that G.N. Patil was the real accused, collapsed in jail and died in hospital, triggering speculation about suicide. Since then, Vishram's widow Rajni has fought a bitter battle, sending petitions to the prime minister, to Sonia, and to the President.

The Congress says most of the charges are politically motivated. It has also defended her by stating that "none of these allegations touch her personally as they deal with institutions, and even in the murder case, G.N. Patil is not mentioned in the chargesheet or the FIR". Perhaps that is something for the liquidators of the bank, the auditors of MDCB and the CBI—which is now looking into the murder

PRIME MINISTER

Manmohan Singh dubs the controversy around Pratibha as "pure mud-slinging".



COURTING CONTROVERSY: Pratibha with husband